Government Schemes and Policies for Girl Child and Women Empowerment

The future of a country hinges on ensuring the generations to come are adequately represented, qualified and able to carry the mantle of development. As a nation, our past is rife with gender inequality but aiming to rectify that situation; the Government is taking steps to empower, educate and uplift the girl child.

Central and State Government policies and schemes that are targeted at improving the lives of girl child in India are mentioned below

1. Beti Bachao Beti Padhao Scheme
2. One Stop Centre Scheme
3. Women Helpline Scheme
4. UJJAWALA : A Comprehensive Scheme for Prevention of trafficking and Rescue, Rehabilitation and Re-integration of Victims of Trafficking and Commercial Sexual Exploitation
5. Working Women Hostel
6. Ministry approves new projects under Ujjawala Scheme and continues existing projects
7. SWADHAR Greh (A Scheme for Women in Difficult Circumstances)
8. NARI SHAKTI PURASKAR
9. Awardees of Stree Shakti Puruskar, 2014 & Awardees of Nari Shakti Puruskar
10. Awardees of Rajya Mahila Samman & Zila Mahila Samman
11. Mahila police Volunteers
12. Mahila Shakti Kendras (MSK)
13. NIRBHAYA

(source- https://wcd.nic.in/schemes-listing/2405)

The Ministry of Women and Child Development is implementing various schemes/programmes for empowerment of women and development of children across the country. The details of those schemes are as follows:

For Women empowerment:

Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY), {erstwhile Maternity Benefit Programme} has been contributing towards better enabling environment by providing cash incentives for improved health and nutrition to pregnant and nursing mothers.

Scheme for Adolescent Girls aims at girls in the age group 11-18, to empower and improve their social status through nutrition, life skills, home skills and vocational training

Pradhan Mantri Mahila Shakti Kendra scheme, promote community participation through involvement of Student Volunteers for empowerment of rural women.

National Creche Scheme to provide day care facilities to children of age group of 6 months to 6 years of working women who are employed.

Rastriya Mahila Kosh (RMK) to provide micro-credit to poor women for various livelihood support and income generating activities at concessional terms in a client-friendly procedure to bring about their socio-economic development.

Swadhar Greh to provide relief and rehabilitation to destitute women and women in distress.

Ujjawala, a Comprehensive Scheme for prevention of trafficking and for rescue, rehabilitation, re-integration and repatriation of victims of trafficking for commercial sexual exploitation.

Working Women Hostels for ensuring safe accommodation for women working away from their place of residence. Under this scheme, 2 new proposals have been received and 2 sanctioned in Himachal Pradesh during last three years.

Schemes of One Stop Centre (OSC) and Women Helpline (WH) are being implemented to facilitate access to an integrated range of services including medical aid, police assistance, legal aid/ case management, psychosocial counseling and temporary support services to women affected by violence.

Gender Budgeting Scheme is being implemented as a tool for mainstreaming gender perspective at various stages of planning, budgeting, implementation, impact assessment and revisiting of policy/programme objectives and allocations. The Scheme helps in strengthening of institutional mechanisms and training of various stakeholders so as to mainstream gender concerns in Central and State Governments.

For Child Development

Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) Scheme is being implemented through States/UTs with the aim of holistic development of children upto 6 years of age and to meet nutritional needs of pregnant women and lactating mothers.

Integrated Child Protection Scheme (ICPS) (now Child protection Services) is being implemented through the State Government/UT Administrations to create a safe and secure environment for overall development of children in need of care and protection in urban and semi-urban areas.

National Nutrition Mission (NNM): The Government of India has approved setting up of National Nutrition Mission (NNM) commencing from 2017-18. The NNM, as an apex body, will monitor, supervise, fix targets and guide the nutrition related interventions across the Ministries. The programme through the targets will strive to reduce the level of stunting, under-nutrition, anaemia and low birth weight babies.

Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao

Launched with initial funding ofRs.100 crore the scheme aims to address the issue of the declining child sex ratio image (CSR) and is a national initiative run jointly by the Ministry of Women and Child Development, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and the Ministry of Human Resource Development. **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP),** a comprehensive programme is being implemented to address the declining Child Sex Ratio (CSR) and related issues of empowerment of women over a life-cycle continuum.

Highlights

- It's focused on multi-sector action in 100 districts across the country with a low CSR.
- Aims at generating awareness about the importance of girl children and improving the efficiency of welfare services intended for girls in India.
- Working towards preventing female infanticide.
- Under the BBBP scheme, even district-level education officials must ensure that the benefit of free elementary education reaches all the girls in their area.

Sukanya Samriddhi Yojna

Part of the 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' campaign, this Government of India backed saving scheme is targeted at the parents of girl children. The programme encourages them to build a fund for future education and marriage expenses for their female child. Parents can start saving early as the minimum amount of investment required is small, and the account is active for 14 years from the date of opening the account.

Highlights

- It has tax benefits and an interest rate of 9.1%.
- It is meant for girls under the age of 10 years.
- You can start the account with just Rs 1,000.
- The maximum deposit is Rs 1,50,000 per year.

Balika Samridhi Yojna

This scheme was launched by the Government of India on 15th August 1997 and covered all girls born on or after 15 August 1997 who are below the poverty line. Aimed at offering financial aid to girl children born on or after 15 August 1997, the schemes key objectives include improving the enrolment and retention of the girl child in schools and helping raise daughters until their legal age of marriage. If successful, young girls will get an education that will help them with jobs to generate a steady income.

Highlights
Gift deposit of Rs 500 at birth and second fixed amount deposited every year of school she progresses until class 10.

- Up to Class 3rd - Rs 300 per year
- For Class 4 - Rs 500 per year
- For Class 5 - Rs 600 per year
- For Class 6 & 7- Rs 700 per year
- For Class 8 - Rs 800 per year
- For Class 9 & 10 - Rs 1000

Only one girl child per family can use this scheme.

CBSE Scholarship Scheme/Policy for Girl Education
This central government scheme is available at Government CBSE schools only. It is applicable for one girl child per family across India and aims to supplement the school tuition fee.

Highlights
- Relaxation of Rs 500 per month in school tuition fee.
- The girl should have scored at least 60% or 6.2 CGPA in her 10th board exams.
- The girl child should be the single girl child of her parents.
- Her school fees should not be more than Rs 1500 a month.

While many of these programs tackle the issue of savings and education, some like the **Kishori Shakti Yojana** also aim to educate adolescent girls about the importance of health care. Adolescent girls get access to current and updated healthcare initiatives and learn about good hygiene. As future mothers to be, knowing about 13 life-saving vaccines that the government provides free of cost and the importance of MMR, Polio and similar vaccination is integral to their health and reducing child mortality through vaccine-preventable diseases in the future.

State Government Sponsored Schemes for Girl Child in India

Apart from the central government, the Indian State governments also actively offer several schemes that benefit girl children. Some of these include:

- Rajshri Yojna - Rajasthan
- Girl child protection scheme - Andhra Pradesh
- Sivagami Ammaiyar Memorial girl child protection scheme - Tamil Nadu.
- Ladli Laxmi Yojana - Madhya Pradesh.
- Ladli - Delhi & Haryana
- Mukhyamantri Laadli Yojna – Uttar Pradesh
- Mukhyamantri Kanya Suraksha Yojna - Bihar
- Ladli scheme - Haryana
- Kishori Shakti Yojana - Odisha
- MAMTA scheme for girl child - Goa
- Saraswati Bicycle Scheme - Chhattisgarh.
- West Bengal Kanyashree Prakalpa - West Bengal
- Bhagyalaxmi scheme - Karnataka

References:

1. https://wcd.nic.in/schemes-listing/2405
2. https://pib.gov.in/newsite/PrintRelease.aspx?relid=175325
3. https://wcd.nic.in/schemes/beti-bachao-beti-padhao-scheme